TOPIC 02 · SKILLS AND RULES
LAB 4 THEME · WORKBOOK RULES & PERSONALISATION

Lab 4 — Clean Messy Client Orders with Cleanup, Personalisation and Rules

Maps to	LO2: set personal preferences, use Copilot's automated cleanup, and write a .Rules worksheet that makes Copilot clean and calculate a messy export the same way every time
Duration	40 minutes
Tools	Excel · Copilot (Allow editing, Chat only) · Personalization · Clean data with Copilot · .Rules worksheet · XLOOKUP
Mock data	data/BrightPath_Client_Orders_Raw.xlsx
Lab files	rules-template.txt (the .Rules text to paste into column A)
Course	Microsoft 365 Copilot for Excel (C34) · v3.0
Prompts	https://tertiarycourses.github.io/C34-Microsoft-365-Copilot-for-Excel/prompts/#lab-4

Goal

Turn a messy client-orders export into a clean, consistent table with short prompts, because the workbook's .Rules sheet already holds the standards.

What You Will Do

BrightPath's order system exports client orders that several people typed by hand: 'WIP', 'in progress' and 'Ongoing' all mean In Progress, regions are written 23 ways and client names carry 'Pte Ltd' suffixes. You will save your own preferences in Personalization, try Copilot's automated cleanup, then create a .Rules sheet that defines the workbook's standards. With the rules in place, a one-line prompt builds a clean table, and the same rules shape the XLOOKUP and budget columns you add next.

What You Will Build

Your Personalization (saved to your account) and BrightPath_Client_Orders_Raw.xlsx with a .Rules sheet, a clean tblOrdersClean table (5 statuses, 5 regions, 12 clients), Rate, Delivered_Value, Budget_Used and Over_Budget columns, and a Checks sheet that proves the clean-up

Prerequisites

- Topic 1 completed: you can switch Copilot modes, keep or undo changes, and verify with formulas.
- This lab folder's data/BrightPath_Client_Orders_Raw.xlsx and rules-template.txt.

Data note

Use only the supplied fictional BrightPath data or information you are authorised to process. Do not paste credentials, confidential business material or real employees' personal data into Copilot, rules or skills.

Steps

Step 1. Copy BrightPath_Client_Orders_Raw.xlsx from this lab's data folder into a work-c34 folder on your computer and open it in Excel for Microsoft 365 (desktop). Work on this local copy - no OneDrive upload is needed. Check that Formulas > Calculation Options is Automatic, then open Copilot from the Copilot button on the Home tab or the floating Copilot icon at the bottom right. Read the About_This_Data sheet before you prompt. Scroll through Orders_Raw and spot three ways the same status or region is written.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
Sheets : About_This_Data | Orders_Raw (64 orders, not a table) | Rate_Card (tblRateCard) |
Prompt_Log
Messy : 20 Status spellings | 23 Region spellings | 51 Client spellings
Clean : 5 statuses | 5 regions | 12 clients
```

Step 2. Personalisation is about you, not this file. In the Copilot pane select Settings (...) > Personalization, type the preferences below one per line, select Save and then start a New chat. They now apply in every workbook you open. A prompt that asks for something different still wins.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
Charts : Use column charts rather than bar charts unless the category labels are long.
Colours : Use navy #1F4E79 and teal #2A9D8F as the main chart colours.
Layout : Never merge cells; leave one empty column between blocks of content.
PivotTables : Give fields readable names, e.g. Hires instead of Sum of Hires.
```

Step 3. Try automated cleanup. Click inside Orders_Raw and select Data > Clean Data (or Show suggestions if Excel offers 'Clean data with Copilot'). Hover over each suggestion to see the cells it affects, then Apply the extra-space and capitalisation fixes. Then ask Copilot what is still inconsistent: cleanup fixes typing, but it cannot know that WIP means In Progress or that C means CENTRAL - that needs rules.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
CHAT ONLY:
On Orders_Raw, list the distinct values in Status, Region and Client with a count of each.
Group the values that probably mean the same thing. Do not change anything.
```

Step 4. Create the rules sheet. In the prompt box select + (Add work content) > Create workbook rules. Copilot adds a .Rules sheet with suggested rules. Replace them with BrightPath's rules: open rules-template.txt from this lab folder, copy every line, click .Rules!A1 and paste (each line lands in its own cell in column A), or send the prompt below. Keep the .Rules sheet visible - Copilot ignores a hidden one.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
ALLOW EDITING:
On the .Rules sheet, replace everything in column A with these rules, one per cell from A1
down.
Keep each ## heading in its own cell. Do not change any other sheet.
## ABOUT THIS WORKBOOK
Orders_Raw is the original export. Do not sort, delete or add rows on Orders_Raw. Build
cleaned data on new sheets.
One row = one client order, identified by Order_ID.
Put "Created by Copilot" and today's date in cell A1 of every new sheet you create (except the
Checks sheet), and start the data in row 3.
## DATA VALUES
Status must be one of: Open, In Progress, On Hold, Completed, Cancelled. Map every variation:
WIP and Ongoing = In Progress; Done and Closed - filled = Completed; Not started and New =
Open; Paused and Hold = On Hold; Canceled and Client cancelled = Cancelled.
If Notes say the work is paused, the Status is On Hold, whatever the Status column says.
Region must be one of: CENTRAL, EAST, NORTH, NORTH-EAST, WEST (upper case). For example C =
CENTRAL and Northeast = NORTH-EAST.
Client is the short trading name with no legal suffix, in title case. For example QUILLON
SYSTEMS PTE. LTD. = Quillon Systems.
Owner names are trimmed and in title case, exactly as in tblRateCard[Owner].
## DATES AND MONEY
Text dates in Orders_Raw are day-first. For example 09/03/2026 is 9 March 2026.
Show dates as dd-mmm-yyyy, for example 09-Mar-2026.
```

```
Budget is in Singapore dollars. Convert text such as 12.5k, SGD 12,500 and $12,500 to the number 12500.
Format money as S$ with thousands separators and no decimals, e.g. S$12,500. Show negative values in red in brackets.
## TABLES AND FORMULAS
Format every new data range as an Excel table named tbl + the sheet name without underscores, e.g. tblOrdersClean.
Use XLOOKUP for lookups and return "Not found" when there is no match.
Never merge cells.
```

Step 5. Apply the rules with a one-line prompt in a New chat. Copilot reads .Rules before it works, so you do not repeat the standards. Inspect the result: A1 says Created by Copilot, the table is tblOrdersClean, ORD-302 and ORD-303 are On Hold (their notes say the work is paused), dates read like 09-Mar-2026 and budgets are numbers formatted as S$. Select Done to keep it.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
ALLOW EDITING:
Create a new sheet Orders_Clean with a clean copy of every order on Orders_Raw, following the workbook rules.
```

Step 6. Prove the clean-up. Ask Copilot to add independent checks on a Checks sheet. Each result must equal the expected value in Test It.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
CHECK (Allow editing):
Create a sheet named Checks. Enter these labels and formulas exactly as written, then tell me each result:
A1 Orders B1 =ROWS(tblOrdersClean[Order_ID])
A2 Distinct statuses B2 =COUNTA(UNIQUE(tblOrdersClean[Status]))
A3 Distinct regions B3 =COUNTA(UNIQUE(tblOrdersClean[Region]))
A4 Distinct clients B4 =COUNTA(UNIQUE(tblOrdersClean[Client]))
A5 In Progress B5 =COUNTIF(tblOrdersClean[Status],"In Progress")
A6 Total budget B6 =SUM(tblOrdersClean[Budget])
```

Step 7. Add calculated columns. The rules already say to use XLOOKUP with 'Not found' and how to format money, so the prompt only states the business logic. Check one row by hand: ORD-326 is 358 hours x S$115 (Priya Nair) = S$41,170 against a budget of S$36,500, so it is over budget.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
ALLOW EDITING:
In tblOrdersClean add: Rate from tblRateCard by Owner; Delivered_Value = Hours_Logged x Rate; Budget_Used = Delivered_Value / Budget as a percentage with 1 decimal; Over_Budget = "Yes" when Delivered_Value is greater than Budget, otherwise "No".

FOLLOW-UP:
On the Checks sheet, add the label Total delivered value in A7 with =SUM(tblOrdersClean[Delivered_Value]) in B7, and the label Over budget in A8 with =COUNTIF(tblOrdersClean[Over_Budget],"Yes") in B8.
Then list the over-budget orders.
```

Step 8. Add a rule, then reuse it. Rules can grow: ask Copilot to add one, then apply it with a short prompt. Rules are saved in the file, so a colleague who opens this workbook gets them too. Log your prompts.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
ALLOW EDITING:
Add a rule under ## TABLES AND FORMULAS on the .Rules sheet: Highlight rows where Over_Budget
is Yes in light red.

ALLOW EDITING:
Apply the workbook rules to tblOrdersClean.

LOG (Allow editing):
Prompt_Log already lists every prompt in this lab. For each one I ran, fill in What Copilot
did and How I verified, and set Decision to Keep. I will tell you any row to change to Revise
or Undo.
```

Sample Prompts

Use these prompts in the Copilot pane (or adapt them). Name the table and columns, state the output, and always verify the result. The same prompts are in sample-prompts.txt in this lab folder.

Copy-ready prompts online:
https://tertiarycourses.github.io/C34-Microsoft-365-Copilot-for-Excel/prompts/#lab-4

#	Purpose	Prompt
1	Create rules	Create a .Rules worksheet based on the formatting already used in this workbook.
2	Add a rule	Add a rule to my .Rules worksheet that all charts should use navy #1F4E79 and teal #2A9D8F.
3	Apply rules	Create a new sheet Orders_Clean with a clean copy of Orders_Raw, following the workbook rules.
4	Find variants	List the distinct values in Status and Region with counts, and group the ones that mean the same thing.
5	Rules + lookup	Add Rate from tblRateCard by Owner and Delivered_Value = Hours_Logged x Rate to tblOrdersClean.
6	Question	Which client has the largest total budget, and how many orders does it have?
7	Explain	Which rules on the .Rules sheet did you follow to clean the Status column? Give two examples.
8	New sheet	Create a new sheet showing orders with a budget over S$50,000 by Owner.

Test It

Check	Expected result
Orders and distinct values (Checks B1:B4)	64 orders; 5 statuses, 5 regions, 12 clients
Status counts	Open 10, In Progress 24, On Hold 6, Completed 21, Cancelled 3
Paused orders	ORD-302 and ORD-303 are On Hold
Total budget (B6)	S$3,250,500
Delivered value and over budget (B7, B8)	S$1,961,030; 10 orders over budget
Sample ORD-326	358 h x S$115 = S$41,170 vs budget S$36,500 - Over_Budget Yes

Checkpoint

Keep the workbook in work-c34. Your Personalization stays with your account for the rest of the course.

Troubleshooting

If this happens	Fix
Copilot ignores the rules.	The sheet must be named exactly .Rules (with the full stop), be visible, and have the rules in column A. Start a New chat after changing it.
Create workbook rules is not in the + menu.	Create a sheet named .Rules yourself and paste rules-template.txt into A1, or ask Copilot: 'Create a .Rules worksheet with these rules ...'.
There is no Clean Data button.	It is rolling out and may be missing in your build. Skip Step 3 - the rules in Steps 4-5 do the same job.
ORD-302 or ORD-303 still shows Open.	Copilot missed the Notes rule. Ask: 'Apply the rule about paused work in Notes to tblOrdersClean.'

Challenge

Make a rule respond to the workbook: put a dropdown in .Rules!B1 with Executive and Analyst, and in A20 enter =IF(B1="Executive","New summary sheets show totals only","New summary sheets include a detail table"). Switch the dropdown and ask for an order summary by Region each time.

Reflection

Which three corrections do you give Copilot most often? Which belong in Personalization, and which in a workbook's .Rules?